IBM AI Racing League

Terms & Conditions | Version 2.0

1. Overview

1.1 The IBM AI Racing League ("the Competition") is a student challenge organised by IBM volunteers ("the Organizer"). Teams design, code, and optimise an autonomous AI race car in a racing simulator, using the technology prescribed for each season.

1.2 The Competition is run in seasons. Each season has its own Season Rules, published on the official channels, which form part of these Terms.

2. Eligibility

2.1 Participation is open to students who meet the age and enrolment requirements in the Season Rules for that season.

2.2 Team size limits are set in the Season Rules.

2.3 Every team member must register individually through the official registration channel for that season. Participation is free of charge.

2.4 The Organizer may ask for proof of eligibility at any time. Participants must give accurate information when registering.

3. Season Rules

3.1 For each season, the Organizer publishes Season Rules covering at least:

- important dates (registration, submission, evaluation, announcements)
- team size and eligibility details
- required technology and tools
- mandatory training
- the submission package and how to submit it
- the evaluation format, tracks, and scoring or ranking method
- prizes and recognition

3.2 Where the Season Rules and these Terms conflict, the Season Rules take precedence for matters specific to that season, and these Terms take precedence for everything else, including intellectual property, conduct, data privacy, and liability.

4. Technical Requirements

4.1 Teams must use the simulator, programming language, and tools set out in the Season Rules.

4.2 Unless the Season Rules say otherwise, teams may modify only the AI code that controls the car. They must not alter the simulator, car physics, track definitions, or other competition infrastructure.

4.3 Use of AI-assisted development tools is permitted and encouraged, provided the submission remains the team's own work and the tools' licence terms are respected.

5. Mandatory Training

5.1 Every team member must complete the training named in the Season Rules before the submission deadline. Teams with members who have not completed it may be disqualified.

6. Submissions

6.1 Each team submits one complete package through the official submission channel by the deadline in the Season Rules. Late or incomplete submissions may be rejected.

6.2 The package contents are listed in the Season Rules. They may include source code, a repository link, videos, a car livery, and documentation of the team's journey.

6.3 Submitted code and repositories must be publicly accessible for evaluation. Teams must keep them accessible until results are announced.

6.4 Videos must identify the team, and where applicable its institution, as required by the Season Rules.

6.5 Car liveries must not contain IBM branding, third-party trademarks, or offensive, discriminatory, or unlawful content.

7. Evaluation and Judging

7.1 Teams are evaluated using the method set out in the Season Rules. This may include timed qualification runs, head-to-head races, and judge assessment.

7.2 Tracks, groupings, and seeding may be selected randomly or by a method defined in the Season Rules.

7.3 The Organizer may review all submitted code and may disqualify any submission that contains code designed to harm other competitors or the fairness of a race. Examples are deliberately crashing into opponents, blocking in an unsportsmanlike manner, or interfering with the simulator or other cars' code.

7.4 The Organizer's decisions on evaluation and results are final and binding.

8. Prizes and Recognition

8.1 Prizes and recognition for each season are described in the Season Rules.

8.2 All prizes are subject to availability and the Organizers's internal approval. Prizes are non-transferable and have no cash equivalent.

8.3 The Organizer may modify prize arrangements at any time.

9. Intellectual Property

9.1 Teams retain ownership of their submitted code.

9.2 By submitting, teams grant the Organizer a non-exclusive, royalty-free, worldwide licence to share, feature, and publish submitted videos, social media and blog content, livery designs, and team information for promotional and educational purposes.

9.3 Submissions must be original or properly licensed. External libraries and open-source code are permitted if clearly documented in the repository. Submissions must not infringe third-party rights.

10. Conduct and Integrity

10.1 Submissions must be the team's own work.

10.2 Teams must not tamper with the simulator, car physics, track definitions, or other competition infrastructure, and must not manipulate results or falsify credentials.

10.3 Teams must behave respectfully towards other participants, organisers, and judges, including on social media and community channels.

10.4 The Organizer may disqualify any team for breach of these Terms, misrepresentation, or unsportsmanlike behaviour, with immediate effect.

11. Data Privacy

11.1 Personal data collected during registration and participation (including name, institution, contact details, and submitted content) will be processed by the Organizer only for competition administration, prize fulfilment, communication of results, and the promotional uses described in section 9. Participants may withdraw at any time by contacting the the Organizer team.

12. Liability and General Provisions

12.1 The Organizer is not responsible for technical issues, connectivity problems, or submission failures outside its direct control.

12.2 The Organizer may amend these Terms or the Season Rules, including deadlines and prizes, and may cancel, suspend, or modify the Competition at any time without liability. Changes will be communicated through the official channels.

12.3 These Terms are governed by the laws of the jurisdiction of the Organizer's legal entity administering the Competition. Disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of the competent courts in that jurisdiction.

12.4 Participation constitutes full and unconditional acceptance of these Terms and the current Season Rules.

13. Official Channels

13.1 Registration, submission, community, and learning links for each season are published in the Season Rules and on the Competition's official channels.

Season Rules: Winter 2026

Code. Collaborate. Conquer. | Intelligent Racing.

Overview

Eligibility	Students aged 18+ (high school, college, or university) Europe only season. Eligible countries: Albania, Andorra, Austria, Belgium, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Bulgaria, Croatia, Cyprus, Czechia, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Ireland, Italy, Kosovo, Latvia, Liechtenstein, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, Moldova, Monaco, Montenegro, Netherlands, North Macedonia, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Romania, San Marino, Serbia, Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, Ukraine, United Kingdom, Vatican City
Team size	1 to 3 members
Registration	Each member registers individually via MS Forms (https://ibm.biz/ai-race-reg)
Technology	TORCS; Python; IBM Bob (VS Code fork). Run natively on Windows or Linux, through WINE on macOS, or use the pre-made image with TORCS included Account created on IBM SkillsBuild platform (link available upon registration to the Competition). Account created on Discord platform (link available upon registration to the Competition).
Mandatory training	Each member completes the following learning path on IBM SkillsBuild platform: "IBM AI Racing League"

Submission

Each team submits one MS Forms entry containing a link to a public GitHub repository with:

- the Python code for the car
- the livery for mass-start racing
- a team video of up to 2 minutes (introduce the team, explain the approach, make a difference)
- links to 3 social media posts about the team's journey (Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn)

Evaluation

Code check. All code is reviewed for harmful behaviour (for example, deliberately crashing into opponents) and may be disqualified.

Phase 1, Solo Qualification. Each car runs alone for 3 laps on a randomly selected track. The best (fastest) 24 times qualify for the mass start.

Phase 2, Mass Start. Races have 6 cars and run on randomly selected tracks. The 24 qualifiers are snake-seeded into 4 heats of 6 cars. 20 qualifiers are selected on best (fastest) time, 4 qualifiers are a wildcard rewarded for those teams that have most supporters. In event of a draw on time or number of supporters, random choice is applied.

- Heats: 4 races, 3 laps each. The top 3 from each heat advance.
- Semifinals: 2 races, 3 laps each. The top 3 from each advance.
- Grand Final: 1 race, 6 cars, 5 laps.

The best time in Grand Final wins.

Dates, Prizes, and Links

Prizes:
All members from the teams qualified in Solo Qualification get a certificate of achievement.
Prizes may include IBM merchandise, mentoring opportunities with IBM professionals, and the opportunity to showcase your work within IBM globally.

Dates:

Registration deadline is December the 31tst, 2026.
Submission deadline is December the 31st, 2026.
Semifinals and Grand Finals: January the 29th 2027 (exact time to be announced on Discord channel)

Registration link:

https://ibm.biz/ai-race-reg